

Psalms 37

Fret Not Thyself

Fret not thyself because of evildoers

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Fret not thyself because of evildoers, neither be thou envious against the workers of iniquity.*
- 2 *For they shall soon be cut down like the grass, and wither as the green herb.*
- 3 *Trust in the LORD, and do good; so shalt thou dwell in the land, and verily thou shalt be fed.*
- 4 *Delight thyself also in the LORD; and he shall give thee the desires of thine heart.*
- 5 *Commit thy way unto the LORD; trust also in him; and he shall bring it to pass.*
- 6 *And he shall bring forth thy righteousness as the light, and thy judgment as the noonday.*
- 7 *Rest in the LORD, and wait patiently for him: fret not thyself because of him who prospereth in his way, because of the man who bringeth wicked devices to pass.*
- 8 *Cease from anger, and forsake wrath: fret not thyself in any wise to do evil.*
- 9 *For evildoers shall be cut off: but those that wait upon the LORD, they shall inherit the earth.*
- 10 *For yet a little while, and the wicked shall not be: yea, thou shalt diligently consider his place, and it shall not be.*
- 11 *But the meek shall inherit the earth; and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace.*
- 12 *The wicked plotteth against the just, and gnasheth upon him with his teeth.*
- 13 *The Lord shall laugh at him: for he seeth that his day is coming.*
- 14 *The wicked have drawn out the sword, and have bent their bow, to cast down the poor and needy, and to slay such as be of upright conversation.*
- 15 *Their sword shall enter into their own heart, and their bows shall be broken.*
- 16 *A little that a righteous man hath is better than the riches of many wicked.*
- 17 *For the arms of the wicked shall be broken: but the LORD upholdeth the righteous.*
- 18 *The LORD knoweth the days of the upright: and their inheritance shall be for ever.*
- 19 *They shall not be ashamed in the evil time: and in the days of famine they shall be satisfied.*
- 20 *But the wicked shall perish, and the enemies of the LORD shall be as the fat of lambs: they shall consume; into smoke shall they consume away.*
- 21 *The wicked borroweth, and payeth not again: but the righteous sheweth mercy, and giveth.*
- 22 *For such as be blessed of him shall inherit the earth; and they that be cursed of him shall be cut off.*
- 23 *The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD: and he delighteth in his way.*
- 24 *Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down: for the LORD upholdeth him with his hand.*
- 25 *I have been young, and now am old; yet have I not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his seed begging bread.*
- 26 *He is ever merciful, and lendeth; and his seed is blessed.*
- 27 *Depart from evil, and do good; and dwell for evermore.*
- 28 *For the LORD loveth judgment, and forsaketh not his saints; they are preserved for ever: but the seed of the wicked shall be cut off.*
- 29 *The righteous shall inherit the land, and dwell therein for ever.*
- 30 *The mouth of the righteous speaketh wisdom, and his tongue talketh of judgment.*
- 31 *The law of his God is in his heart; none of his steps shall slide.*
- 32 *The wicked watcheth the righteous, and seeketh to slay him.*
- 33 *The LORD will not leave him in his hand, nor condemn him when he is judged.*
- 34 *Wait on the LORD, and keep his way, and he shall exalt thee to inherit the land: when the wicked are cut off, thou shalt see it.*
- 35 *I have seen the wicked in great power, and spreading himself like a green bay tree.*
- 36 *Yet he passed away, and, lo, he was not: yea, I sought him, but he could not be found.*
- 37 *Mark the perfect man, and behold the upright: for the end of that man is peace.*
- 38 *But the transgressors shall be destroyed together: the end of the wicked shall be cut off.*

39 *But the salvation of the righteous is of the LORD: he is their strength in the time of trouble.*

40 *And the LORD shall help them and deliver them: he shall deliver them from the wicked, and save them, because they trust in him.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalm 37 is a wisdom acrostic tackling the age-old problem of the prosperity of the wicked, answered with a repeated refrain: fret not, trust, wait, rest, commit. It promises the meek will inherit the earth—quoted by Jesus in Matthew 5:5—and pictures the wicked withering like grass while the righteous, though they may stumble, are upheld by the Lord’s hand. Both Henry and the broader evangelical tradition treat it as a direct antidote to envy of evildoers, urging a patient, long-view faith rather than a demand for immediate justice.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Fret not because of evildoers, nor be envious of workers of iniquity, for they shall soon be cut down like grass. Instead trust in the Lord, do good, dwell in the land, feed on His faithfulness, and delight yourself in the Lord, who will give you the desires of your heart.

Verse 5-9

Commit your way to the Lord, trust also in Him, and He shall bring it to pass. Rest in the Lord, wait patiently for Him, and cease from anger and wrath, for fretting only leads toward evil; evildoers will be cut off, but those who wait upon the Lord shall inherit the earth.

Verse 10-15

Yet a little while and the wicked shall not be—his place will not be found. The meek inherit the earth and delight themselves in abundant peace. The wicked plots against the just and gnashes his teeth, but the Lord laughs, seeing his day of judgment coming; the sword drawn against the righteous ends up piercing the wicked man’s own heart.

Verse 16-20

A little that the righteous have is better than the riches of many wicked, for the arms of the wicked shall be broken while the Lord upholds the righteous. The righteous are not ashamed in the evil time and are satisfied even in days of famine, while the wicked perish and consume away like smoke.

Verse 21-26

The wicked borrows and does not repay, but the righteous is generous; those blessed by the Lord inherit the earth, and those cursed by Him are cut off. The steps of a good man are ordered by the Lord, and though he falls he is not utterly cast down, for the Lord upholds him with His hand; from youth to old age, David has never seen the righteous forsaken nor his descendants begging bread.

Verse 27-31

Depart from evil, do good, and dwell forevermore, for the Lord loves justice and does not forsake His saints—they are preserved forever, while the seed of the wicked is cut off. The righteous shall inherit the land and dwell in it forever; their mouth speaks wisdom because the law of their God is in their heart, and their steps do not slide.

Verse 32-36

The wicked watches the righteous, seeking to slay him, but the Lord will not leave him in the wicked’s hand nor let him be condemned when judged. Wait on the Lord and keep His way, and He will exalt you to inherit the land and see the wicked cut off; David had seen the wicked in great power, spreading like a green tree—yet he passed away and could not be found.

Verse 37-40

Mark the perfect (blameless) man and behold the upright, for his end is peace, while transgressors are destroyed together and the end of the wicked is cut off. But the salvation of the righteous is of the Lord, their strength in time of trouble; the Lord helps and delivers them from the wicked and saves them because they trust in Him.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

The prosperity of the wicked is real but temporary, while the security of the righteous is often quiet and unglamorous yet permanent, upheld directly by the Lord’s own hand. Fretting, envy, and anger accomplish nothing that patient trust, doing good, and waiting on the Lord do not accomplish better and without the corrosion of bitterness.

Application for life today.

Identify the specific person or situation currently tempting you to fret or envy, and consciously replace that fretting with the psalm’s alternatives: trust, delight, commit, rest, wait. When you stumble (v. 24), remember the promise is not that the righteous

never fall but that the Lord upholds them when they do. Practice “mark the perfect man” (v. 37) by looking for quiet, faithful examples rather than only loud, prosperous ones.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where right now are you tempted to “fret” over someone else’s apparent success at your expense—and what would trusting instead look like today?

2. How does verse 23–24’s picture of a good man who stumbles but is upheld change how you view a recent failure of your own?

3. What would it mean this week to “delight thyself also in the Lord” (v. 4) rather than in the outcome you are anxiously waiting for?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).